

URBAN DARING

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Josep-Lluis Sert has just been honored with the highest award given an architect in this country. The Cambridge architect believes deeply in designing for city life. But to many who live among them, his Boston and Cambridge buildings are still controversial.

By Robert Campbell

America's highest prize for architecture has gone to a Cambridge architect who's always been something of a prophet without honor in his own town.

Josep-Lluis Sert this week joined such immortals as Frank Lloyd Wright, Buckminster Fuller, Louis Sullivan, and Le Corbusier — and more recently Philip Johnson and I. M. Pei — as recipient of the Gold Medal of the American Institute of Architects. The award was made in recent ceremonies at the AIA convention in Minneapolis.

Sert is probably better known in Europe or even India than he is in the United States. Yet the greatest concentration of his work is in and around Boston, where he also served as dean of the Graduate School of Design at Harvard, chairman of the Cambridge Planning Board, and adviser to Edward Logue during the heyday of Boston urban renewal in the 1960s.

The amazing fact, which would probably please Sert, is that most of his buildings here remain very controversial, even though they've been part of the skyline for quite a while. They stick out. They have a heady, free-wheeling, experimental quality. They're not timid, not mannerly. And they show a willingness to be big, original, and strange, qualities that reflect a time when architects thought they were being asked to make a new world rather than nurse along an old one.

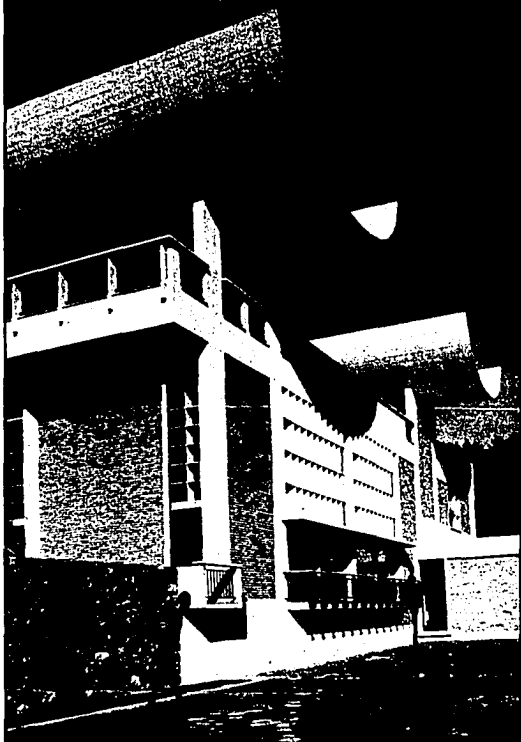
None of this perturbs Sert, whose roots lie deep and safe in the tradition of the modern movement and in the age-old architecture of his native province of Catalonia in Spain. But it does make for a paradox, one that is all too typical of our time. On the one hand,

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ROBERT CAMPBELL, A PRACTICING ARCHITECT IN CAMBRIDGE, IS THE GLOBE'S ARCHITECTURE CRITIC.

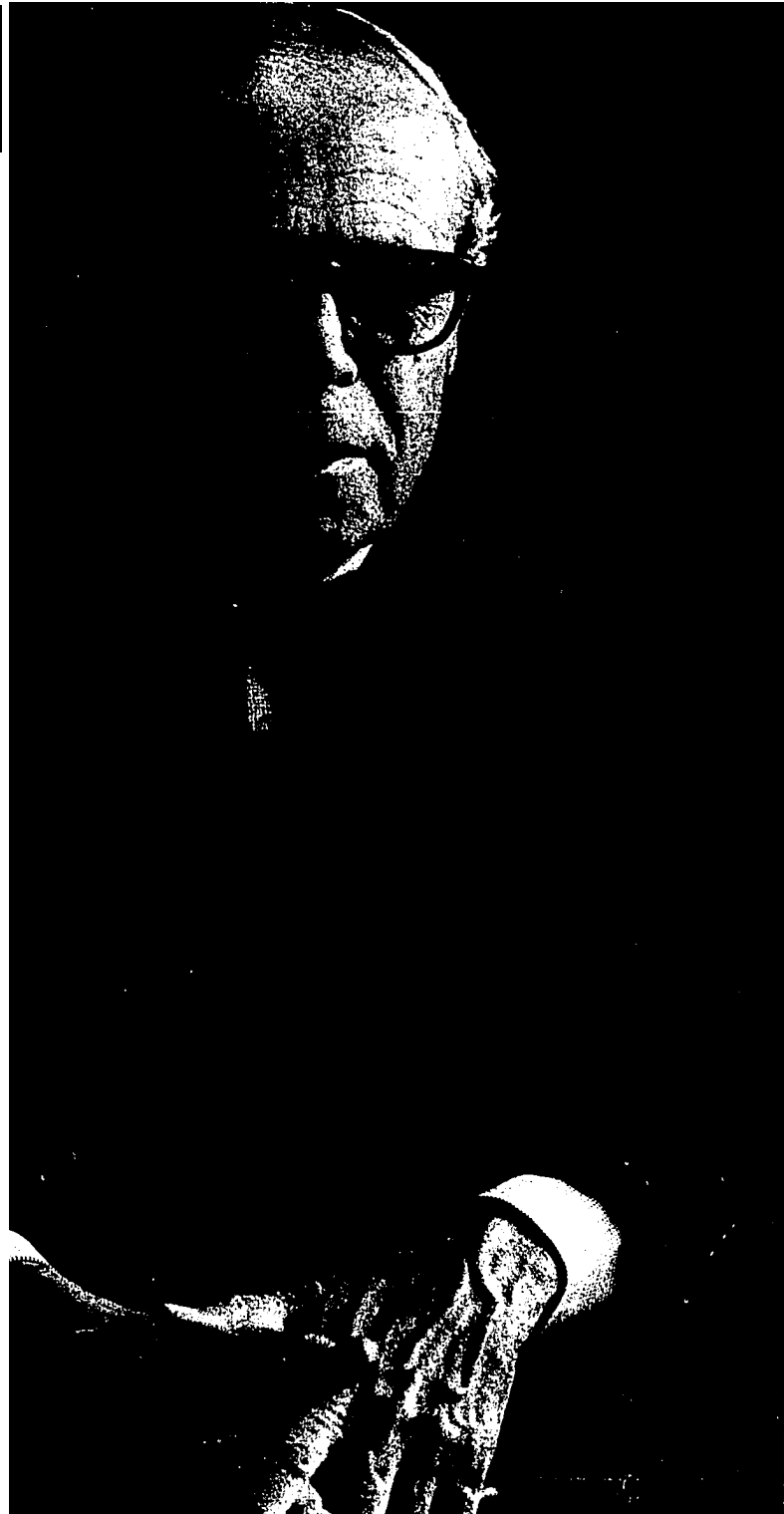
The Maeght Foundation in France. In Sert's mind, his buildings always stand in a Mediterranean light.



Sert in his Cambridge office. A frustrated artist, he says, "I came from painting to architecture."



Holyoke Center, a mini-city with shops, offices, and an arcade, embodies Sert's urbanist ideals.



Photographs: Sert by F. Catala Roca; Maeght Foundation by Claude Caspari; Peabody Terrace by Laurence Lowry; Holyoke Center courtesy of Sert, Jackson and Associates; Boston University by Steve Rosenthal

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there is world recognition for Sert among other architects (he holds the French Gold Medal, too). On the other hand, there are puzzled reactions to his buildings among those who live with them.

This isn't so much a problem of Sert's way of designing as it is a larger problem of the divergence in values that came to separate architects and artists from the general public during much of this century.

Perhaps the Gold Medal will help bridge that gap. If it gets us looking at Sert's buildings and thinking about them, it will indeed be helpful. They are full of vitality, gaiety, and fresh ideas. Even when they don't fully come off, their daring holds lessons for other architects.

Some of those buildings are the Holyoke Center in Harvard Square; the Peabody Terrace apartments on Memorial Drive in Cambridge; the Harvard Science Center; and a complex of buildings for Boston University that include the Sherman Student Union, the Law and Education Tower,

and the Mugar Memorial Library. Sert has also done dormitories at MIT, two MBTA stations, a good deal of housing for the elderly, and in Cambridge, the Martin Luther King School, a small office building at 44 Brattle Street, and the New England Gas and Electric building in Central Square.

His notable works in other places include two wonderful art museums, the Maeght Foundation in Saint-Paul-de-Vence in southern France and the Miro Museum in Barcelona, Spain. Sert also designed most of the buildings for Roosevelt Island in New York City.

Sert's architecture draws its strength from four directions: two personal interests and two outside sources.

The personal interests are Sert's lifelong passion for the world of art and his equally long fascination with cities, their urban spaces and their way of working.

The outside sources are Le Corbusier, the Swiss-French master who was Sert's mentor, and the peasants of the Spanish Mediterranean, who created a folk architecture of

strength and simplicity."

Mix these four ingredients together, and you pretty much have Sert the architect.

The love of art started with Sert's childhood in Barcelona. His uncle was Jose Maria Sert, a muralist who won a sort of fame by accepting Rockefeller gold to paint out the work of Diego

Basic to Sert's work are a passion for art and a fascination with cities.

Rivera in Rockefeller Center because Rivera had included a portrait of Lenin. Young Josep-Lluis wanted to be a painter, too.

"I came from painting to architecture," he recalled recently. "Somebody, I suppose, told me, well, as a painter nobody makes a living. My father said that's not a career, and he wanted me to study something. I think it was my uncle the muralist who said, 'Why don't you be-

come an architect?'"

The world of art was a heady one in those days. Uncle Jose Maria was married to Misia Sert, a legendary Paris figure of the teens and twenties. She introduced young Josep-Lluis to other legends: Diaghilev, Ravel, Vuillard. Later he came to know Picasso, who like the Serts was from Catalonia, on the Spanish coast. This led to a collaboration between Sert and Picasso at the World's Fair of 1937 in Paris. Sert helped design the Spanish Pavilion, and he and Picasso planned the size and location of a mural Picasso was to paint for it. The mural was *Guernica*, probably the most famous painting of the century.

It all seems ordinary enough to Sert.

"I was just part of a scene, the late twenties in Paris," he said. "It was a much smaller world then than now, with a small minority of people interested in modern art. I met a man like Giacometti, the sculptor, because we used to go to the Cafe des Fleurs near the Deux Magots in Saint-Germain." Artists from the

Paris of that time became some of Sert's closest friends: Alexander Calder, Jean Miro, Fernand Leger.

This lifelong involvement with the world of art is a basic part of Sert the architect, but no more basic than his interest in cities, in urbanism.

Probably, in fact, the best way to understand Sert the architect is to see him as two people: a frustrated painter (who never did paint) and a frustrated urbanist (who never built any cities, though he certainly tried). Eventually, rather late in life, Sert began to create an architecture that expressed both those sides of himself.

The painter and the urbanist don't always coexist peaceably in Sert's buildings, but it's out of that tension that their vitality is born.

Sert the painter is forever trying to make his buildings into works of art, creating patterns on their facades, studying their sculptural shapes. Sert the urbanist has very different goals. He is always trying to expand the building, to connect it with city pathways, to turn a mere building into a miniature town.

It was Sert the urbanist who created the nation's first degree program in urban design at Harvard. And it was the urbanist who persuaded Harvard, when the university wished only to build a new infirmary, to enlarge its horizons to create the Holyoke Center, a mini-city including shops, garages, offices, and an arcade. Sert the painter then brought to the result a contrast of rough concrete with pale gray glass, touches of intense color, carefully patterned windows, and a picturesque, broken roofline.

The Holyoke Center also embodies Sert's modernist faith, which remains undimmed, in the power of the machine to improve human life. It has a Tinker Toy facade of machine-made parts that look as if they could be rearranged at will to accommodate changes in the interior floor plan. Though this really isn't possible, it's a metaphor for the flexible, humane building of the future.

As noted above, Sert's main sources of formal ideas are the peasant cottages of Catalonia and the works of Le Corbusier, the

great architect who was the central figure of the modern movement. After fifty-five years, Sert recalls in vivid detail the moment he found Le Corbusier, a moment that changed his life.

"It was 1926 when I first discovered Le Corbusier in a little bookseller that still exists near the Place Vendôme in Paris. I hadn't heard of him. I just saw these books of his — *Toward a New Architecture* and others. They intrigued me very much. I brought them back to Barcelona, where we were a group of unhappy students in an old-fashioned Beaux-Arts school. We had been looking for some kind of new orientation, different from what the school was teaching us. Well, we found it there."

The students invited Corbusier to lecture to them. Later, Sert worked in Corbusier's Paris office.

As for the peasant work, that too was an interest of the students.

"My friends and I at the university were very much influenced by the folk architecture," Sert said. "We found that the new modern architecture we saw in the magazines

resembled many of our old buildings in the Mediterranean. These new buildings had flat roofs and they were all white like our poorer houses. And they had the same volumetric expression and simplicity of means. So we found that these things were not really so modern in our country as they appeared in the North."

In his imagination and in his drawings, Sert's buildings always stand in a Mediterranean light. A Sert design without sunshine on it can be a gray ghost of itself — sometimes a problem, to be sure, in a Boston January. Among his finest works is the series of little-known houses he designed for friends over the years on the small island of Ibiza, off the coast of Spain, in an adaptation of the peasant-style stucco houses of white and ochre that spill down the bare hills toward the blue water.

Like many architects, Sert was a late bloomer. He and his wife, Moncha, left Europe when the dictator Franco took over Spain. The move hurt his career, and it wasn't until the late fifties, when Sert himself was past 50, that he got much

work. By then he had headed of the design school at Harvard, succeeding Walter Gropius. The firm of Sert, Jackson and Gourley (now Sert, Jackson and Associates) was founded in 1958, when the commissions finally began to arrive in a flood. It continues to be active today, with Sert, now 78, listed as a consultant.

When Sert the architect finally emerged, he seemed to arrive full-blown with a style of his own — a sort of playful marriage of Corbusier and Catalonia. The heavy concrete sunshades that appear on a Corbusier building such as the Carpenter Center at Harvard, for instance, become in Sert's nearby Science Center something much lighter, festive attachments to the building, almost like banners or flags. What Sert calls the "nude" architecture of early modernism put on bright clothes and quite a lot of what can only be called ornament, though ornament in those days was not an acceptable term.

"Yes, I was introducing ornament," Sert said. "I always felt that modern architecture, when it came into the

realm of the city, would have to have a richer vocabulary and a lot of the older ideas that had been thrown out would have to be carefully picked up.

"When I came to America I saw more modern, and more bad modern, than there was in Europe. I was perfectly convinced that it would be very sad and dull to see whole cities develop on the limited modern formula. It would be like a whole museum the size of the Louvre filled only with Mondrian and his disciples. It would be a disaster."

In 1958, Sert built a house for himself and Moncha on land Harvard owned. Typically, it wasn't just a house. Sert the urbanist expanded the program, designing a prototype row house with three courtyards. Sert the painter then made it one of the most beautiful houses in America. A living room opening to courtyards on two sides is dominated by a Catalanian altarpiece that fills one end, in visual dialogue with a large Miro painting over the sofa. The Miro and the altarpiece, masterpieces both, are a reminder of Sert's equal love of the present and the past —

and, incidentally, of his devout Roman Catholic faith. They exemplify a description he once gave of Miro's painted sculptures: "Across the empty, unpainted spaces they watch one another closely, silently, tensely."

In this house live Sert and Moncha — they have no children — surrounded by art, "in a lucidity and warmth which fills its space and informs its visitors," as Robert Gardner, director of the Carpenter Center, has written. Here also Sert's love of society and delight in repartee are manifest.

In a recent conversation, Sert picked Harvard's Peabody Terrace as his favorite among his own buildings, then added the Science Center, the Miro Museum, and the Maeght Foundation.

Every one of these works, as it happens, contains a courtyard, which leads naturally enough to a final Sert warning on the current scene:

"For me, the twentieth century as we've lived it up to now may go down in history as the century that destroyed the urban space." ■